

DOUG MCCALLUM COMMITS TO PROTECT ROSEMARY HEIGHTS RETREAT CENTRE LANDS AS PARKLAND

McCallum pledges to oppose residential development, change the land-use designation to greenspace and parkland, and pursue City acquisition of the property

Surrey mayoral candidate Doug McCallum is committing to protect the former Rosemary Heights Retreat Centre lands from residential development and pursue their permanent preservation as greenspace and parkland if elected Mayor in 2026.

The commitment follows concerns raised by the Rosemary Heights Community Association regarding the proposed redevelopment of the lands at 3660 and 3690 152nd Street.

After reviewing the Association's report and concerns regarding the environmental significance of the property, wildlife connectivity, traffic safety, school capacity, parking and infrastructure, McCallum said his position remains the same as the commitment he made to Rosemary Heights residents in 2018.

"Rosemary Heights residents have been fighting to protect these lands for years, and my position is clear: I do not support residential development on this property," said McCallum. "These lands should be protected as greenspace and parkland for future generations."

In September 2018, while campaigning to return as Mayor, McCallum publicly opposed the development proposal for the former Retreat Centre property and supported exploring the City's ability to acquire the lands and preserve them as parkland.

McCallum was subsequently elected Mayor in October 2018, and the proposed residential development did not proceed during his term.

"I stood with Rosemary Heights residents in 2018, and I stand with them today," said McCallum. "This is not a new position or a new election promise. I made a commitment to protect these lands eight years ago, and I intend to finish the job."

If elected Mayor in 2026, McCallum is committing to:

- Oppose the proposed residential rezoning and redevelopment of the former Rosemary Heights Retreat Centre lands;
- Work with Council to amend the applicable City land-use planning framework, including the Official Community Plan and any applicable successor planning framework, to designate the property as greenspace and parkland;
- Direct City staff to once again explore the City's options to purchase the property, subject to appropriate valuation, negotiations and Council approval; and
- Work toward securing the lands as public parkland so their environmental and community value is protected for future generations.

McCallum said Surrey must accommodate population growth and new housing, but that responsible planning also requires governments to recognize that some environmentally significant lands should be protected rather than developed.

“Surrey needs housing, but that does not mean every remaining piece of land should be developed,” said McCallum. “Once we lose a mature forest, riparian habitat or an important wildlife corridor, we cannot simply recreate it somewhere else.”

The Rosemary Heights Community Association has identified the property as part of an important ecological connection associated with the Nicomekl River and Surrey's broader Green Infrastructure Network. The Association has also raised concerns regarding the effect that hundreds of additional residential units could have on surrounding roads, intersections, schools, parking and community infrastructure.

McCallum said revisions that reduce the number of proposed residential units do not change the fundamental issue.

“This isn't a debate about whether 233 homes are better than 375 homes,” said McCallum. “The question is whether these environmentally significant lands should be developed for residential purposes in the first place. My answer is no.”

McCallum said that, if elected, his objective will be to provide protection through Surrey's land-use planning framework while simultaneously pursuing the City's opportunity to acquire the property.

“We will protect the land through our planning framework and pursue its acquisition so that it can be preserved as parkland,” said McCallum. “The commitment I made to Rosemary Heights residents in 2018 still stands in 2026.”

Protect it. Preserve it. Keep it for future generations.

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